Bande Mataram

Sir,

Some of the native gentlemen of Tuticorin are of opinion that in view of the welfare of the SSNCo of Tuticorin, I should not enter on politics, and that these townsmen should not celebrate the release of Sri [Bipin Chandra] Pal. As all the people residing in this town should necessarily join together and discuss about those matters and decide them, I request that all Swadeshis should assemble at the 'Pallivasal Pettai' in Peria Kattan [Great Cotton] Street in Tuticorin.

Tuticorin, 8-3-'08 V.O. Chidambaram

Guruswami Aiyar promptly passed on this notice to Wynch along 'with a simple chit' and advised him to keep an eye on the proposed public meeting.[55] On receipt of this notice, Wynch, in a move to scuttle the planned celebrations of Bipin Chandra Pal's release on 9 March,[56] ordered security proceedings against VOC, Subramania Siva and S. Padmanabha Aiyangar. (As we may recall, under British rule, district collectors were also magistrates thus wielding both executive and judicial powers.) Summons were issued under Section 107 of the Criminal Procedure Code, ordering them to present themselves before the district magistrate, a position held by the district collector himself.

What followed is history.

On the evening of 8 March, a 'monster meeting' was held attended by over 4,000 people. It was an emotional gathering with Subramania Siva moving the crowd to tears with his heartfelt words. Speaking at the meeting, VOC said some friends had asked him to go to Bombay to escape arrest but he had replied, 'Let the Government deport me!' VOC said he wanted to consult the masses before responding to Wynch's notice summoning them to Tirunelveli. Given the risk of externment from Tuticorin/Tirunelveli, he said he had been advised by friends to go away to Bombay for a time. But he had asserted that any decision would be taken only after consulting the people. Continuing in this vein, he boldly stated: 'If the European officials give me a bond that if I go away and close my connection with the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company, they will not